

Chapter 4. About Japan

On December 7, the epidemic control measures that had lasted for three years were suddenly revoked. Public policy here remains as ridiculous as in the past. There is no need to believe a single word, because any given sentence could "*no longer hold any practical relevance*" the very next day, and all the costs are borne solely by the ordinary people.

The powerful industrial capacity boasted over and over again during the past thousand-plus days and nights suddenly vanished. Not enough medicine, not enough masks, not enough hospital wards; it was hard to see any difference from those "failed states in fighting the pandemic" living in abysmal misery that the *Xinwen Lianbo* (national evening news / 新闻联播) reported on day and night.

It was precisely in such absurd times that most people around me, myself included, caught COVID-19 once, and then recovered within a few days, except that the sore throat lingered a bit longer.

Taking advantage of this period when everyone was sick, I simply put aside the academic materials I couldn't comprehend. I increasingly felt that I had reached the end of my academic path. I secured a recommendation for graduate school in October, but I was already acutely aware that I probably lacked the capability to pursue a Ph.D. in mathematics. My family did not support it either, so combined master-doctoral programs or direct Ph.D. programs were even less necessary to consider.

During the final days of epidemic control, I began to ponder the history of Japan, because early on I had noticed that the history of Japan—perhaps China's most important neighbor aside from Mongolia—possesses a highly pronounced uniqueness.

Moreover, this uniqueness is easily linked to its national conditions. Japan and China are neighboring countries; from around the Common Era to today, whether in peace or war, interactions have been continuous. Japan started relatively late and historically studied China for a protracted period. Even today, many of the cultural products that serve as Japan's international calling cards originally stemmed from China.

But on the other hand, Japan today is a developed capitalist country, boasting a standard of living that leads Asia, advanced science and technology, and an excellent international image. Furthermore, over the century and a half since the Meiji Restoration, Japan has indeed politically accomplished "*Leaving Asia and Entering Europe*" (*Datsu-A Nyū-Ō* / 脱亚入欧), and the values recognized by its citizens are now virtually indistinguishable from those in Europe and America.

This implies that Japan can form two distinct control groups with China and the West, respectively. Researching the differences in the historical trajectories of these three might just be the key to clarifying how modern society was born.

Among the widely recognized developed countries and regions in the contemporary world, excluding microstates, they either experienced the Eurasian Great Migrations following the end of the classical era, or were formed through overseas colonization since the Age of Discovery (*including today's Taiwan region of China*). The sole exception is Japan. This highly ethnically homogeneous country neither went through the Eurasian Great Migrations nor was formed from colonies.

This single characteristic alone demonstrates that if anyone wishes to understand how modern society was formed, it is impossible for them not to study the history of Japan.

Moreover, as mentioned in previous records, the official post of Grand Governor of the Capital Environs (*Jingji Dadudu* / 京畿大都督) during the Eastern Wei period is extremely similar to the *Rokuhara Tandai* (六波罗探题) of the early Kamakura period. This makes Japan's **feudalization** (封建化) a highly worthy historical event to study.

Because I do not understand Japanese, I read the domestically translated Chinese versions of Kodansha's *A History of Japan* (10 out of the 26 volumes), Iwanami's *History of Japan*, and the University of Tokyo's *History of Japan*. I was indeed profoundly struck by the professional caliber, academic ethics, and achievements of Japanese scholars; they have already researched their own country's history extremely thoroughly.

Thanks to the monumental enterprise achieved by these predecessors, I am able to utilize the history of Japan as such a clean and bright mirror for China. If the Japanese back then considered the history of the Kamakura Shogunate to be the "Mirror of the East" (Azuma Kagami / 《吾妻镜》或称《东鉴》), then the entire history of Japan will also serve as China's "Mirror of the East."

四、关于日本

12月7日，持续了三年的疫情防控措施突然之间就被撤销了，这里的公共政策依然跟往昔一样可笑，每一句话都没有相信的必要，因为任何一句话在第二天都可能“不再有现实意义”，而所有的代价都由老百姓承担。过去一千多个日日夜夜里被吹嘘的一遍又一遍的强大的工业能力突然就不见了，药品不够，口罩不够，病房也不够，很难看出跟新闻联播里面日夜播报的那些水深火热的“抗疫失败国家”有什么区别。就是在这么荒唐的时光里，包括我在内周边的大部分人都得了一次新冠肺炎，然后在几天之中也就恢复了，就是嗓子疼会持续地久一点。趁着这段大家都在生病的时候干脆把学不懂的东西也放下，我是越来越感到自己的学业已经看到头了，十月份的时候保上了研，但我已经很清楚自己怕是没有能力读个数学博士了，家里也不支持，所以硕博连读、直博什么的更是没必要考虑。

在疫情管控最后的时间里，我开始思考日本的历史，因为很早的时候我就注意到日本这个或许是除了蒙古以外中国最重要的邻居的历史具有非常强的特殊性。而且这种特殊性很容易与其国情联系在一起，日本与中国是邻国，从公元前后到今天无论是和平还是战争交流不断，日本起步相对较晚，在历史上长期学习中国，直到现在，日本在世界上能称得上是名片的许多文化产品最初都源于中国。但是另一方面，日本今天又是一个发达资本主义国家，人民生活水平亚洲领先，科学技术先进，国际形象极佳，而且自从明治维新以来至今一个半世纪，日本的确在政治上完成了“脱亚入欧”，其国民认可的价值观念已与欧美无异。这就意味着日本可以与中国和西方分别构成两组对照组，通过研究三者历史进程的差异或许就是弄清楚现代社会如何诞生的关键。当代世界被广泛承认的发达国家和地区中，除掉袖珍国家以外，或者经历过古典时代结束后的欧亚民族大迁徙，或者是地理大发现以来经过海外殖民所形成（包括今天中国台湾地区），而唯一的例外就是日本，这个民族相当单一的国家，既没有经过欧亚民族大迁徙，也并非由殖民地形成。单从这一个特点就表明，任何人如果想要了解现代社会是怎么形成的，就不可能不去研究日本的历史。况且在之前的记录中就已经提到，东魏时期京畿大都督这一官职与镰仓早期六波罗探题极为相似，这就使得日本的封建化变成一个非常值得研究的历史事件。因为不懂日语，所以我阅读了国内汉语译版的《讲谈社 日本的历史》（26卷中的十卷）、《岩波日本史》和《东京大学日本史》，的确为日本学者的专业水平、学术道德和取得的成就所折服，他们已经把自己国家历史研究的极为透彻了。多亏前人取得了这样的事业，我才能得到日本史这样一个对中国而言干净明亮的镜子，如果说当年日本人认为镰仓幕府的历史是“东镜”，那么整个日本的历史也会是中国的“东镜”。